

The Battle of Issus, 333BC

Alexander's next major battle came at Issus in Syria in 333BC. His army numbered between 25 000 and 42 000 foot and 5000 cavalry. His opponent this time was Darius III, the Persian king, who supposedly had 250 000 to 600 000 men. Alexander forced a battle in a narrow plain between the mountains and the sea, to reduce Darius' advantage of superior numbers. Alexander commanded the Companion cavalry on the left wing. He stretched his infantry across the battlefield to stop any Persian outflanking move and gave orders for a rapid advance to minimise the effect of Persian archery. He knew that he was outnumbered and that having to cross the Pinarus River would disadvantage his infantry.

Once again, as at Granicus, a bold move was needed. Alexander charged through the *kardakes* on

the Persian left wing with his Companions and headed for the Persian centre where the Greek mercenaries were. Darius stood behind them. On seeing Alexander, Darius lost his nerve and ran. This caused morale problems throughout the reserve troops behind him. Alexander and the Companions then swung into the Persian centre and cut the Greek mercenaries to pieces allowing the *pezetairoi* and *peltasts* to cross the river bed and gain the upper hand. The Persians ran when they saw the mercenaries being defeated.

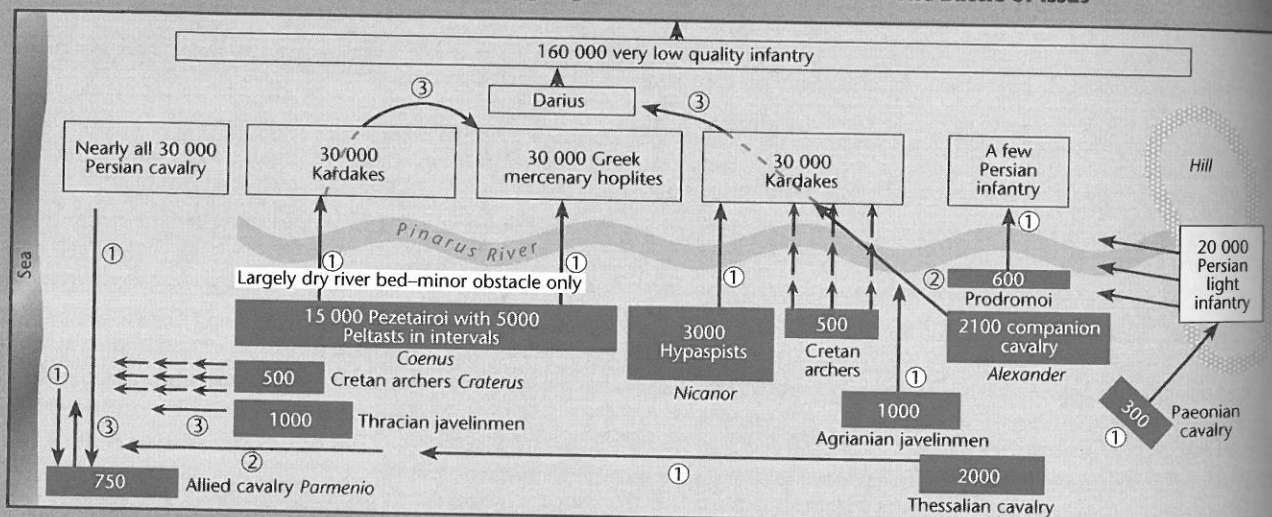
The Persians lost some 100 000 men compared to 450 Macedonians killed and 4500 wounded. Again bravery, experience and clever tactics won the day, despite the Persians having more troops and a better battlefield position, holding the upper ground on a river bank.

Results of the victory

The western half of the Persian Empire was now controlled by Alexander. Parmenio was sent to capture the royal treasury at Damascus. Alexander held Darius' war treasury and several female members of Darius' family, including his mother and wife. The path into Egypt now lay open for Alexander. He had proved that he was able to defeat a force much larger than his own by his clever tactics and the discipline and experience of his Macedonian troops.

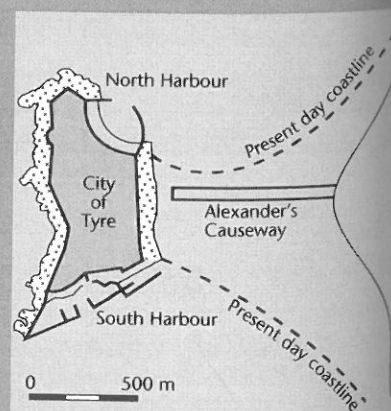
- Copy the diagram below into your books. Redraw it in three stages. Explain in a paragraph what is happening at each stage.
- How did Alexander defeat the Persian king?

The Battle of Issus



The siege of Tyre, 332BC

Alexander had to face a number of difficult sieges during his campaign; most famous was the siege of Tyre. The sea ports along the coast of Phoenicia all gave in without a fight except for the island of Tyre. Alexander set his men to build a wooden causeway to the island but when it was half built the Tyrians crashed a fireship into it and burnt it down. The Macedonians began again. This time they had warships to protect them, because the Cypriot and Phoenician captains in the Persian fleet were deserting to the Macedonian side. Eventually catapults were used to batter at the city walls from three sides—from the completed causeway, from a Cypriot fleet to the north and a Sidonian fleet to the south. Seven months after the siege began the south wall crumbled and Alexander and the hypaspists fought their way in. The causeway is the only one of Alexander's works to survive today.



The city of Tyre